

Brianna Gross
Editor in Chief
Applications in Plant Sciences

April 12th, 2026

Dear Dr. Gross,

I am pleased to submit a software note titled “*safeHavens and eSTZwritR; R packages for prioritising germplasm collections for restoration and conservation*” for consideration in Applications in Plant Sciences.

The two packages described in this manuscript are tools designed to support the development of native germplasm sources for conservation and ecological restoration. *safeHavens*, provides a flexible framework for designing germplasm sampling strategies for plant species worldwide. It implements a range of computational approaches that serve as proxies for population genetic structure, spanning from straightforward geographic methods to Bayesian approaches that account for multiple sources of uncertainty. *eSTZwritR* is built upon a comprehensive review of existing empirical seed transfer zone (eSTZ) data products and seeks to standardize access to eSTZs, the gold standard for guiding germplasm collection and restoration decisions

Both packages are accompanied by unit and integration tests, CodeFactor scans, GitHub Pages documentation sites, metadata for AI-assisted interpretation of functionality, and most importantly comprehensive vignettes and tutorials to support their usage. The manuscript describes the motivation for the software and outlines key technical capabilities, while directing readers to the vignettes for detailed, applied guidance

Applications in Plant Sciences is an ideal venue for this work. By framing germplasm collection as a fundamentally collections-based activity, we hope to increase the efficiency and rigor of restoration and conservation efforts in more general alignment with natural history museums. APPS is praised for its editors, papers, and special issues, for pushing the boundary of natural history museums forward.

We affirm that this submission is original, has not been published elsewhere, and is not under consideration by another journal. Some materials detailing the functionality of *eSTZwritR* were presented in a more limited scope at the 2025 National Native Seed Conference poster session in Tucson Arizona; hence the name ‘easy rider’. There are no conflicts of interest to disclose.

Thank you for considering this submission. I look forward to your response.

Sincerely,
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